



Learning to Say 'No'

"You have to decide what your highest priorities are and have the courage—pleasantly, smilingly, non-apologetically—to say 'no'..."

—Stephen Covey

Snapshot 37.1

RAJIV SHARMA, THE 'YES' MAN

Mr Rajiv Sharma is not just your average business analyst. He is a business analyst plus a superman. He is ten employees rolled into one. He is the official trouble shooter and the unofficial 'go-to' guy when things get a bit rough around his cubicle. He has a heart of gold and never says no to anyone.

Take last Monday evening, for example. It was 5.00 p.m. Sharma was just putting the finishing touches to his feasibility report when his next-cube neighbour came rushing in for some help with inserting a graph into an Excel file. 'That should be easy' Sharma declared, as he volunteered to help—but it was only after delving into the problem did he find out that it was not that simple. Quite challenged, he sat up the next hour trying to help his friend. In the middle of it, someone walked by his desk to remind him of the 6.00 p.m. conference call with Ireland. Somebody else pulled him into a conference room for five minutes because the overhead projector was acting up. While he was out doing it, Mr Banerjee walked into Sharma's cube

with a business proposal he had written that he wanted Sharma to look over and give feedback on. Just when Sharma got back to his desk, his boss dashed in and dragged him over to his office because his Japanese client was on the phone about something that only Sharma knew. In the middle of all this, his wife rang him up to remind him that he was supposed to pick her up from her office and drive over to her grand-aunt's ninety-third birthday party. Didn't Joshi borrow his motorcycle for the afternoon?

Life is no doubt hectic for Sharma. But he would rather extend his helping hand and be popular than quietly do his job in a corner, unperturbed. He is so glad that so many people count on him and that he is an important hub of his organization. He knew that there could not be a conference call within two miles of his desk without him taking part in it. He is proud of donning so many roles—business analyst, the great communicator, Excel expert and a caring relative who takes the time to look up an old lady. He often reaped rewards and recognition for his selfless attitude—not to mention the eternal gratitude of the many people he helped. No wonder he is considered an elite employee who was always the first one to be summoned at the slightest hint of trouble.

But of late, Sharma has been re-thinking his Mr Nice Guy policy. He was finally starting to get tired of saying 'yes' to everyone who needed help. He began to notice that he was overdoing it to the point where he had no time for the most important person in his life, namely himself. He was stretching himself thin and was beginning to wear down. His efficiency was dropping, interruptions were becoming more annoying and he found his days shrinking. More importantly, his effectiveness was dropping and he was not completing what he was supposed to deliver. Most times, he had trouble finishing his own work. Enough was enough! He was going to add a new word to his vocabulary called 'no'.

Snapshot 37.2

SRINI VARADRAJAN, THE EVER SOFT-SPOKEN PROJECT MANAGER

Mr Srin Varadarajan is the quintessential customer-facing project manager, doing high-pressure software projects for his US client. His client asks him in a conference call, 'By the way Srin, I forgot to tell you . . . my management wants to add in the new costing feature to our billing system that does . . .'. Srin makes a quick calculation in his head and reckons this new feature will take an additional ten person months that will throw a spanner in the project cost. But instead of coming out and saying 'If we add this feature now, it will cost an additional half a million dollars and push the release schedules off by another three months' or something to that effect, he in his typical 'soft-spoken' nature says, 'Hmm . . . that will take quite a bit of time . . .' The foreign counterpart bulldozes by saying 'C'mon, you can do it man . . .'. Srin replies 'Let me see what I can do . . .'

This 'let me see what I can do' is taken as a 'yes' by the US counterpart. (And Srini would never be firm even in his e-mail about the specific extent of damage of this seemingly innocuous request for change.) What should have been categorically and professionally stated has now been beaten around the bush.

Clearly, Srini neither has the confidence nor the intention to meet the new demands that his foreign counterpart made and was meaning to say 'no'. But he is soft-spoken enough to not to say a loud 'no' (and in the back of his mind, he does want to explore the possibilities of accommodating his business partner's requests). Meanwhile, his more aggressive and forceful US counterpart has presumed that he has arm-twisted Srini into saying 'yes'. Although the US partner is wrong in interpreting Srini's actions, the onus is on Srini to be more clear-cut and less ambiguous on such a binary decision as saying yes or no. We would say that such instances of wishy-washy communication and sending mixed or wrong messages can cause more trouble and heartaches than the previous case of Rajiv Sharma.

37.1 THE TWO TYPES OF WRONG YES-S

There is a bit of Rajiv and a bit of Srini in all of us (see Snapshots 37.1 and 37.2). You must have sometimes said 'yes' to things that you should have really said 'no' to and later lived to regret it. Without thinking, sometimes you tend to be very generous with your time or things to the point of placing somebody else's needs ahead of your own or your project's welfare. True, these generosityes can earn you a lot of goodwill, but how much sacrifice should you make without jeopardizing your self-interest or the interest of the project that your organization has entrusted you with? Where should you draw the line about saying 'yes' to people and taking on added responsibilities? How do you strike the right balance between saying 'no' to some people and saying 'yes' to some others? Why do you say 'yes' when you actually meant to say 'no'? Is it your ego? How do you say 'no' without sounding rude?

We will try to answer all these questions in this chapter. This chapter will help you recognize the situations where you will have to decide between saying 'yes' and saying 'no'. We will first look at two different scenarios that have the same effect—of making you say 'yes' when you mean 'no'. Then we will see how to say this 'no' in a courteous, acceptable way. Finally, once you decide to say 'no', we will see how not to be pressured into saying 'yes'.

Rajiv and Srini present two scenarios by which a wrong yes is given (when a no is what should have been said). Rajiv is the one who is always helpful, who does not mind working long hours with the clear intent of helping others. His problem is that he over commits himself and even forgets his priorities. If Banerjee or Joshi feel that they will get all the help they want from Rajiv, this is exactly the impression that Rajiv intended to convey.

But Srini's case is even worse. He did not *intend* to complete the project enhancement. But he has given the wrong impression to his US counterpart that he will

complete it. He has simply been a nice guy on the phone and been an escapist, not willing to put his foot down and articulate a professional 'no'. He is just sitting on a time bomb ticking off and when the US counterpart does realize that what was meant was a 'no', it is going to be too late and too expensive.

There are a couple of reasons why this 'saying yes when you mean no' is so important an issue that it deserves a separate chapter. First, there is an innate belief (more so in India than in the US and in a number of other places that we have seen) that saying no would lead to a bad feeling in the mouth of the other party and will jeopardize the relations in the long run (true of both Rajiv and Srini). Second, there is a tendency to postpone saying no. By postponing, it is hoped that the situation will take care of itself and that the 'no' will no longer be required (the Srini syndrome). Third—and this is something that is complained of often about Indians—they don't say no explicitly. In case of people with the Srini syndrome as seen in Snapshot 37.2, the 'no' is camouflaged as a 'yes'.

The problem arises because you don't have the heart to say 'no' to a helpless colleague or are afraid to be 'disrespectful' of the client by saying 'no'. This attitude stems from the values you learnt as a child—to be unselfish, to help out people who need help and to make sacrifices for the greater good. Now it is time to re-educate yourself into thinking that a well-reasoned 'no' from you is appropriate in several situations and is not the end of the world. It is not even the end of the project, because a good project manager will re-assess the situation and make sure that somehow the right resources are deployed, even if you cannot help out. If you have good reasons for saying 'no', your response will not be considered as negative behaviour and neither will you be thought of as being unreasonable and uncooperative. It will not affect your popularity at work. You don't always have to be a part of the solution to everyone's problems. So get used to the idea that you can indeed say 'no' on occasion and live with that decision. In fact, it is far better than the alternative—saying 'yes' when you had actually meant to say 'no'.

37.2 WHY YOU SAY 'YES' WHEN YOU MEAN 'NO'—THE PROCESS EXPLAINED

Let us walk through the various stages of this process—right from the time when someone needs help and how you get trapped into saying 'yes' to how you get psychologically affected by this wrong response on your part.

Stage 1—People in need of help have you in their cross-hairs: It starts innocuously enough with a boss running into your cube or a colleague phoning in his request. Often the requests are so subtle that you don't even realize that an action item is being solicited. So the first thing to develop is an automatic warning system that a new demand is going to be made on your time and resources. Be alert when someone walks in, be careful about analysing their requests and above all, don't fall head over heels over them. (*The VP of finance is himself coming to me for help. This must be my chance to glory.*)



Fig. 37.1

And why would *they* come to you when they are in need of help? Here are some reasons.

- ▶ They need to get the job done somehow. *Any* help is okay. They just happened to stumble on you.
- ▶ You are an expert in the field (or at least you know more than them).
- ▶ You have a reputation of being patient and generous.
- ▶ You are a pushover.
- ▶ You have the reputation of overloading yourself or you are the 'go-to' person.
- ▶ You are perceived to be relatively 'free' and available for such spontaneous exercises.
- ▶ You can be flattered or ego-fed into doing it.
- ▶ They can use their authority to push you.
- ▶ They need to use that gizmo, gadget, software and so on that you have (umbrella, comb, pen, motorcycle, employee handbook *ad nauseum*).

Stage 2—Why you might want to say 'no': There can be many, many reasons for you to say 'no' to someone, not merely because your plate is full. Sometimes even when you have plenty of time and flexibility in your schedule, you may still want to say 'no' because you may find the proposal to be uninteresting, unnecessary for your career advancement, unpleasant or unrewarding—like the time your boss asked you to be on the 'canteen committee'. Sharma (in Snapshot 37.1) could have said 'no' to helping out with the overhead projector for a variety of reasons—being too busy,

not having enough expertise in the matter and also because the audio-video service technicians are just a phone call away and could be summoned right away. He could have said 'no' to his colleague who wanted to borrow his motorcycle because Sharma needed to leave the office on time. He could have said 'no' also because the colleague was known to be a rash rider—although Sharma would not have explicitly stated that.

Here are some of your reasons for wanting to say 'no' and ways of saying no.

- ▶ You have no bandwidth. You are in the middle of something critical and important for your project.
- ▶ You have other plans and commitments.
- ▶ You don't want to work with the others in this activity (although you may want to state this diplomatically).
- ▶ It is too much of a risk—not an easy request that you feel you can do justice to. ('You certainly need someone with more experience to handle this.')
- ▶ You don't know how to do it. You know you don't have the expertise, even if they think that you do. You know your limitations and don't want to enter into an area that you are not comfortable in. ('I appreciate your confidence in me, but I know my limitations.')
- ▶ You have more fun things to do. You would rather be sleeping (again, be careful as to how you phrase this).
- ▶ It doesn't appeal to you. You just don't want to do it. (There is no reason why you cannot say this directly but politely 'Oh, this is not my cup of tea.')
- ▶ You don't want to lend your things to them because they will not handle them as well as you want them to. ('You know, as a matter of principle, I don't lend this to anyone, even to my wife or brother.')

Stage 3—Why you end up saying 'yes' when you meant to say 'no': Just imagine you are sitting across the table from a foreign contingent. Everyone (except you) is at least a director or higher up. Even the language they use seems superior to anything you have ever heard. You are feeling so intimidated and out of place that you can feel butterflies in your stomach. You somehow want to belong. You want to announce, 'Hey, look. I am capable. Give me some task to do.' And then your boss (who also wants to look good) tells you in front of all of them 'Rajiv, why don't you take care of that activity and do it?' It suddenly feels like the entire project's success, your organization's fortunes and perhaps even the advancement of the human race is in your hands. You scream a loud 'yes' (but it comes out as a feeble whisper of a 'yes'). Scarcely ten seconds later, upon reconsidering your boss's request and mulling over all your other commitments you have pending, you realize that saying 'yes' was a bad idea. You should have actually said 'no' or at least a 'let me see'. Why did you thoughtlessly get into the trap when you were actually way too busy with other projects? You also realize that you don't have a lot of competence in the field he wants you to work

in. Now you cannot back down without looking bad. As a professional, you have to execute. You think you have learnt a lesson and will never do it again. But come next week, you have done it one more time in another context. Why is this happening and what is wrong?



Fig. 37.2

Here are some psychological factors which force you to say 'yes' when you would rather say 'no'.

- ▶ You want to prove yourself and project yourself as powerful, important, Mr or Miss Reliable.
- ▶ Your desire to perform on the international stage.
- ▶ You want to make a positive impression on the client and the boss.
- ▶ You expect monetary and other rewards.
- ▶ It is a cultural thing. You want to prove that you are as good as any in the world.
- ▶ It is a cool thing.
- ▶ You are worried about all kinds of negative consequences if you don't say 'yes'.
- ▶ You don't want to look selfish and self-centred.
- ▶ You are worried that you will miss an opportunity.
- ▶ You are worried about what they will think.
- ▶ You don't want to hurt the other person's feelings.
- ▶ You don't want to seem uncooperative and as not stepping up.
- ▶ You are intimidated into it.
- ▶ Your boss was very persuasive.
- ▶ You feel obligated or are afraid looking bad.
- ▶ In your own mind you are ambivalent and would feel guilty if you had said 'no'.

You say a big fat 'yes', kick yourself and feel miserable.

Stage 4—You live with your decision: When you say ‘yes’ and take on more assignments—even though you had meant to say ‘no’—you are on the hook. As a professional, you are now committed to completing the task in hand (unlike your personal life where you can sometimes say ‘yes’ and later make excuses for not doing it). Your professional ethics dictate that you assume ownership of that activity and go through the whole nine yards. You cannot abandon it or give it a half-hearted attempt just because your mind is not in it.

This can be very agonizing because often, only in hindsight will you realize that you never wanted to do that activity in the first place. This agony itself is a very negative feeling to have. The feeling that somebody has hand-wrung you into doing it and you were not too careful can haunt you for a long time. Also, you will get the feeling that you could rather be doing something else that is more interesting and more rewarding, instead of fixing your colleague’s Excel mistakes.

Here is a short list of what happens to you when you are pressured into doing something because you didn’t know how to say ‘no’.

- ▶ You have no time to do everything properly, given how much there is on your plate and all the deadlines you face.
- ▶ You feel betrayed.
- ▶ You feel like you are sacrificing too much and neglecting your own welfare.
- ▶ You have to work with people you don’t enjoy working with.
- ▶ You get into a wrong project or activity in which you have no competence.
- ▶ It is an activity with no visibility where you will be unappreciated.
- ▶ You feel you will not get the right reinforcements or help.
- ▶ You are psychologically not motivated to perform at your highest level.

37.3 HOW CAN YOU SAY ‘NO’ AND STILL COME OUT AHEAD

An honest evaluation of what is on your plate and what the organization (or a colleague) needs is the key to saying ‘yes’ or ‘no’ to new commitments that come your way. If at the end of your situation analysis you decide that ‘no’ is the appropriate response, how will you convey that response to the other party (and to yourself) in a polite, acceptable way? Here are some suggestions.

Say a firm, unequivocal ‘no’: ‘No’ is perhaps one of the simplest, yet very clearly-understood words in English. So if your answer is no, give it to them straight. Tell them you are sorry, but there is no way you can help them. The abruptness of this response might unnerve you at first. But this takes out any ambiguity in your response. The trouble starts only when you try to give the impression that in spite of your ‘no’, perhaps there is a possibility that you can help them. (‘There is a chance that my boss will not ask me to do this testing, in which case, I may be able to help you’—the Srini syndrome, that we saw in Snapshot 37.2).

Keep smiling and look genuine when you say no. Convey this message through your body language as well. Don't say anything ambiguous or confusing. They should get the impression that yours is a firm 'no', but if you had the time and resources, you would have definitely helped out.

Substantiate with hard data, don't make it look personal: When you say no, tell why. 'After sizing the project, I realize that it will take another ten person months and it will go way beyond the budget we committed to each other. We should defer it to the next release.' By this method, you are not only saying a firm no, but also substantiating it with clear numbers and even offering a solution.

Point out that something else might suffer: If it is your boss or someone high up that is trying to twist your arm into doing something and you cannot look in their eyes and say the word 'no', just point out to the things you are already doing and are committed to. Tell them in no uncertain terms that those things might suffer if you took up extra load. If they still insist on your doing the new activity, ask them to reprioritize your tasks and set their expectation level lower on some of your assignments.

Don't dwell on it and feel anguished about having said no: The guilt feeling can overwhelm you if you said 'no'. The image of a poor, helpless colleague struggling with Excel software, unable to get the graph right, can wrench your heart. What if this happened to you? But let it pass. It is his problem and he will certainly find someone else to help him. Even if he doesn't, you are not the owner of this problem. Don't be emotional about it and agonize over it.

In some other cases, buy time ('let me think about it'): Instead of immediately committing to the request one way or the other, ask for some time to think about the proposal—think offline about it and come up with a response in a reasonable time. This way, your response will be honest and well thought out. Of course, this won't work if someone needs your help right away.

Take on a partial commitment and find a halfway solution or ask for help: It may be possible for you to take on a part of the request instead of the entire thing. Or perhaps you can take on the entire request if you got some help yourself. In that case, suggest this to the requester and they may be amenable to such a suggestion. However, in some cases, they may want the entire activity to be done by one person and your idea may not be feasible.

Don't be defensive: One of the worst things you can do is to keep on apologizing after having said a 'no'. 'I would have helped if my I didn't have this vendor meeting' or 'Just last Thursday I helped someone with a similar request' will only end up making you feel awkward about having said 'no'. Remember that most help-seekers are not very interested in what exactly your circumstances are that made you turn their request down. If you can't do it, you can bet that they will scour the entire office for someone else who can.

How to deal with the boss and other very pushy people: First of all, remember that there will be commitments put forth by your boss that you simply cannot refuse and don't have a choice of saying 'no' to. However, under some circumstances you can stand up to your boss, if you have a case for it. Of course, it will be very difficult to say 'no' to your own boss, because he is all-in-all for you at work and also because somehow, he seems to have a way of coercing you into things.

The strategy here is to not say 'yes' or 'no' explicitly, but discuss the matter completely. Even after you put forth that 'something else might suffer' defence, if he still insists on your doing it, have a bigger and more comprehensive discussion on your role in the organization. Come up with reasons why your entire group might benefit by your not committing to this activity. Have some other neutral observers (such as the project leads) in the discussion to help steer it to a decision.

Stick to your 'no'. Don't let the other person brainwash you: Some people can be persistent. They will walk up to your desk ten times hoping to change your mind just by putting pressure on you. Some others may try to sweet-talk you into it. These are the people who don't easily take 'no' for an answer. The way to deal with them is to be equally hard-lined about your stance and flash the biggest smile you have and splash an even bigger 'no' that you can come up with.

Suggest somebody else or alternative solutions: This is the age-old response in lieu of saying 'no'. But beware. Some people may find it insulting that you are advising them when all they are after was some solid help. And don't use it on your boss—he knows the big picture better than you.

Sometimes you can change your mind and say 'no': Even if you had thoughtlessly said 'yes' to someone, some commitments are reversible and you can later turn around and say 'no' after deliberating the matter for sometime. But do it very, very soon, before the ripple effects start to take shape.

37.4 HOW TO TAKE 'NO' FOR AN ANSWER

The flip side of saying 'no' to someone is that when you request help from your colleague and have to take 'no' for an answer. You may have feelings of rejection or desertion by your colleague and experience anger at being unable to solve your problem. Let us for a moment look at how to take 'no' for an answer, without all that hurt.

Remember they don't have to say 'yes': It is not your birthright to get help when you need it. *They* are simply doing you a favour—and they don't always have to. You should not feel insulted or let down. It is not personal.

Don't keep bugging them. Leave them alone: Take 'no' for an answer. Don't haunt the other person over and over, hoping they would relent on your fifth attempt. In some countries, repeatedly hounding the other person to service your request can be construed as harassment and can lead to legal situations. So draw a line after one or two attempts at persuasion.

Don't let that hurt your pride. Keep asking others. Don't give up: The bottom line is that you will have to solve your problems and it doesn't matter if Sharma is not able to help you. Seek other people or be resourceful in other ways about solving the problem. Think laterally about what else you can do.

Be better prepared the next time: Learn a lesson every time and be better-prepared the next time. Maybe it is time to read up on Excel software so that you get better at it and then you will not have to rely on Sharma to bail you out.

37.5 IN SUMMARY

Learn to say 'no' to some requests that can potentially hurt you somehow or that are not humanly possible for you to pull off. And definitely don't say 'yes' when you meant to say 'no' (see Snapshot 37.3). If you are wont to doing it, you might as well move to some parts of Ethiopia where 'aye' actually means 'no'.

Snapshot 37.3

RAJIV SHARMA, THE 'NO' MAN!

Now Sharma is a changed man. Ever since he learnt to say 'no' he has been able to free up time for himself and for projects closer to his heart. Nowadays, he doesn't get caught up in a cesspool of other people's problems.

Some people who took him and his helping heart for granted are certainly disappointed at his about turn. They think that some evil, jealous persons drove Sharma to be mean and cruel. But even they accept his new personality. Even now he does step in and help people, but only when he has the bandwidth for it. He never gets mixed up between saying 'yes' and 'no'. He is very polite and apologetic about saying 'no', but doesn't dwell on it much or feel defensive about it. It was very tough for him to turn down his own boss at times. But now everyone's view towards Sharma's helping tendencies has changed and no one expects him to be readily available whenever there is trouble around the corner. Sharma is at peace with himself and feels more in control. Also, his popularity has not diminished any because of his change of personality. And oh, by the way, even now the administrative assistant approaches Sharma first when there is a paper jam in the office Xerox machine, before calling the service people. When it comes to fixing paper jams, Sharma is still faster than a speeding bullet.

We also want to dispel any misunderstanding that we are going tangential to our basic philosophy espoused in this book. Throughout this book, we have been asking you to put your organization's interests ahead of your own and be a team player and step up to the plate in crunch time. Now it might seem as if we are giving you the opposite message of being self-centred and looking after your personal welfare.

But actually we are not. We still maintain that when a project is in its critical stages, you must step in, in whatever capacity and help out the team—this includes pulling for colleagues in their activities and taking on additional responsibilities wherever you can. We obviously don't want you to be your own show-stopper. We want to bring your attention to the extreme situation when you over-commit yourself and over-schedule your time and make your life miserable—just because you don't know how to turn down people's requests for help. Your psychological well-being is absolutely important and we don't want you to have a burn-out or get the angst of being a simpleton that everyone takes advantage of.

Once you learn to say no to a few things, you will find that you have more time to do the right things—and to do them more efficiently and effectively. You will find that you are more in control. This will definitely make you integrate better into your environment.

"I think he is trying out various ways to say 'no' without offending the other person.."



Fig. 37.3